



Guideline

Criteria Led Discharge (CLD)

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
SCGH	General Medicine / ACE G71, G74, C16,	Medical and Nursing

Introduction

This guideline describes the best practice for implementing Criteria Led Discharge (CLD) at Sir Charles Gairdner Hospital (SCGH).

CLD is the discharge of patients by nursing staff who have the necessary knowledge and skills to review patients and initiate inpatient discharge. The process occurs under medical direction using defined criteria based on best practice principles to ensure a safe and timely discharge of patients¹.

Criteria Led Discharge has been demonstrated to support the process of timely discharge for patients by:

- Reducing the delays for simple discharges
- Increasing the number of timely discharges
- Reducing length of stay
- Improving quality of care
- Improving patient / family's experience.

Risk Statement

Non-compliance with this policy will:

Breach legislative requirements	☐	Impact on Patient Quality of Care	☒
Breach Hospital Policy	☒	Impact on Patient Safety	☒
Breach professional standards	☒	Misconduct	☐
Breach SCGOPHCG Mission & Values	☐	Staff Safety	☐
Other:	☐		

Definitions

Criteria Led Discharge (CLD) Form	Documentation completed by admitting team (Consultant/Registrar) determining criteria the patient needs to meet prior to discharge via CLD
Consultant Physician	The medical officer credentialed with rights to admit patients and manage clinical governance responsibilities under whom the patient has admitted.
Discharge Criteria	A set of criteria that needs to be met for the patient to be deemed ready, safe and appropriate for discharge.

Principles

- CLD enables appropriately trained SCGH nursing staff to discharge patients under the delegation of the patient's Medical Registrar/Consultant Physician, who will maintain clinical governance over the patient and therefore has the ultimate responsibility for the patient.
- Appropriately trained nurses are those with suitable skills, experience **and** completion of CLD education package
- Agency staff should not undertake CLD.
- A full explanation of this discharge process must be given to the patient. If there are any concerns expressed by the patient or nursing staff providing direct patient care this process should stop and a medically led discharge initiated.
- Ensure relevant information is documented in the patient's medical records by medical staff, nursing staff, allied health and any other health professional providing support of CLD.
- The Notifications and Clinical Summaries (NaCS) for discharge should be commenced by the treating medical team on initiation of CLD.

Procedure

1. Identifying patients suitable for CLD

- The treating Medical team in conjunction with Nursing will identify patients that may be suitable for CLD. This may include:
 - Patients awaiting Transitional Care placement;
 - Patients for transfer to secondary hospital site;
 - Patients transferring to Palliative care: home/hospice;
 - Patients returning home using Patient Assisted Transport Scheme (PATS);
 - Mental Health patients, when medically stable and waitlisted by Clinical Psychiatry;
 - Patients on the completion of treatment therapy according to criteria set.

2. Best practice requirements for CLD

- The Consultant Physician/Registrar is responsible for approving the decision for a patient to be discharged via CLD and for approving the predetermined list of criteria.
- To identify a patient as eligible for CLD early in the patient journey.
- To agree the criteria and subsequent plan for discharge in partnership with the entire health care team, including the patient and/or their carer.
- To continue to review patients every day by the medical team and update the set criteria, if required.
- For the CLD competent nurse to monitor and record if the patient has met the criteria. This does not substitute for clinical judgment and if a patient does not meet the criteria, a medical review is necessary.
- For a transfer of care/discharge checklist to be completed for all patients

3. Recommended CLD Process

- Following the decision that a patient is suitable for discharge using CLD, the Consultant Physician/Registrar is to ensure documentation to this effect is recorded in patient's medical record.
- Utilising a CLD form, the Consultant Physician/Registrar will document the discharge criteria for the patient concerned.

Note: the use of CLD does not replace discharge planning and ongoing clinical monitoring of the patient. The use of CLD is a part of discharge planning. Issues such as follow up requirements should be part of the discharge plan and not affected by the decision to use CLD

- Patient journey boards shall be updated with CLD as part of the discharge process.
- All discharge criteria need to be met prior to discharge of the patient. Should the pre-discharge assessment of the patient reveal that some of the predetermined discharge criteria have not been met; the patient shall be referred to the Consultant Physician/Registrar for discharge as per local hospital processes.
- At the time of discharge, it is the responsibility of the discharging Nurse to ensure that all discharge requirements have been completed and documented. In order to participate in CLD, it must be within the Scope of Practice of the discharging Nurse

Compliance, monitoring and evaluation

Healthcare professionals and in particular nurses, spend a disproportionate amount of time managing the mismatch between when a bed is needed (admission) and when it is available (discharged). Implementing CLD to optimise timeliness of patient discharge from hospital will assist in patient flow and decrease Emergency Department overcrowding.

Acute Services Division Clinical Nurse Consultant General Medicine in conjunction with Executive Sponsor for CLD pathway will undertake compliance monitoring and evaluation of the policy on an annual and as needed basis.

Related Documents

- [NSQHS Standards](#)
- [SCGOPHCG Discharge of Patient Policy](#)
- [SCGOPHCG Clinical Handover – Communicating for Safety Policy](#)
- Criteria-led Discharge Form MR638

References

1. Department of Health, UK. Achieving timely 'simple' discharge from hospital: A toolkit for the multidisciplinary team. 2004. Available from: <https://www.bipsolutions.com/docstore/pdf/8092.pdf>

Authorisation & Version Control

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Standards Applicable:	NSQHS Standards 				

For full details regarding, development, review, consultation, approval, endorsement - contact the Policy Officer for the submission form

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